

to viewing angles, brightness, contrast, and richness of colours being displayed. Almost all Ultrabook displays are glossy in nature, but if you manage to find one that has an anti-glare coating, there's nothing like it.

Build quality and design

Most Ultrabooks we've reviewed and tested are of good build quality – the best ones among them are Ultrabooks offered by Lenovo and Dell. An important difference between Ultrabooks and regular laptops is the Ultrabook's sealed battery compartment, which helps reduce weight and removable parts, therefore strengthening the product's core. Again we advice going to a retailer and trying out the Ultrabook's build quality – keyboard design, touchpad, hinge placement, screen flex, palmrest comfort, etc – before investing your money.

Connectivity options

Remember that Ultrabooks are slimmer, trimmer and lighter versions of regular laptops, in terms of form factor. When you walk that path of cutting down excess, many compromises have to be made regarding components and what goes inside the basic building blocks of a successful Ultrabook. But, worry not, for most Ultrabooks that we've seen don't cut down on the type of connectivity option but on their number. For example, a 15-inch mainstream laptop may come with four USB 3.0 ports, but a space-starved Ultrabook may have only one or two of those ports.

Stuff that doesn't matter RAM

Among all the Ultrabooks launched thus far, we've seen a minimum of 4GB DDR3 RAM (clocked at 1333 MHz) as a

DECISION TIME ULTRABOOKS

Manufacturers are trying to extract higher profit margins by selling them at the price of a high-end mainstream laptop – between ₹50,000 to ₹1,00,000. But if past trends are any indication, as more manufacturers flood the market with plenty of Ultrabook offerings, and as the volume of their sales pick up, their costs will automatically go down. And that's starting to happen. Three months ago would've been too early, but now is the right time to buy an Ultrabook, so go ahead full steam.

standard. This is a good starting point to make the Ultrabook capable of handling almost all everyday tasks without a hitch. Therefore, if you like an Ultrabook's specs but think the bundled RAM is too low, still buy the same Ultrabook model and update its RAM yourself later.

Operating System

Currently, all the Ultrabooks sold in the market come with a flavour of Windows 7 installed on it. Should you delay your Ultrabook buying decision just because Windows 8 hasn't arrived? Definitely not, since all Ultrabooks launched after June 1 are entitled to an upgrade from their existing Windows 7 operating system to the upcoming Windows 8 operating system for a nominal fee of just ₹699, according to Microsoft India. This program will be available till the end of January, 2013. So yes, buy a Windows 7-enabled Ultrabook now and rest assured with the knowledge that your purchase won't be "outdated" any time soon, as far as Windows is concerned.

Onboard sound

Thin laptops (which is what Ultrabooks are) struggle at reproducing quality sound from their tiny speakers. Manufacturers may tout whatever special audio features, but remember that all that doesn't matter when you listen to an Ultrabook's on-board speaker sound. Connecting external speakers helps, but don't buy an Ultrabook for its on-board sound alone.

Recommendations:

Our Ultrabook recommendations are based on Intel's Ivy Bridge architecture. Of all the Ultrabooks we've tested so far, the Dell XPS 14, HP Envy 4-1002tx and Samsung Series 5 are three of the best Ultrabooks out currently available. The Dell XPS 14 is the most premium of the lot, while the HP Envy 4 has a build that is much better than what one expects at its price of ₹56,000.



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